

Eli Lilly and Company is a **Large Public** firm that is based in **Indianapolis, Indiana**. They perform **biopharmaceutical research, development, and manufacturing** for **global patients with chronic conditions**. They are a **multinational corporation**. This firm offers a potential partnership because **their heavy investment in AI-driven drug discovery and clinical trial expansion aligns directly with UNC's strength in biomedical informatics and health data research**.

Markus Saba (retired Eli Lilly senior executive and current Professor of the Practice of Marketing/Executive Director of the Center for the Business of Health at UNC) is the best avenue for partnership because **he possesses deep institutional knowledge of Lilly's internal operations and existing academic credibility within UNC's health business ecosystem**.

Basic Company Information

- **Name, Company Location:** Eli Lilly and Company, Indianapolis, IN
- **Company website URL:** [lilly.com](https://www.lilly.com)
- **Company Type, Company Size:** Public, Large (Approx. 50,000 employees)

Company Type

- **IPO?** Yes (NYSE: LLY) 1952

Company Size

- **Large:** 750+ (Specifically 50,000+)

UNC Connection (if any)

- **UNC Alum (in decision-making position):** Markus Saba (Retired Eli Lilly Executive, currently serving as Executive Director of the Center for the Business of Health at UNC).
- **Donation History:** Lilly has a long history of philanthropic support in healthcare, though specific granular donation history to UNC is best verified via the [UNC Office of Development](#).

Talking Points

- **AI-Driven Drug Discovery:** Eli Lilly is actively integrating generative AI for biologic design, notably through its 2026 collaboration with Chai Discovery and its open-source "Lilly TuneLab" initiative, which provides models trained on proprietary research data to academic partners.
- **Informatics Research Synergy:** UNC's biomedical informatics infrastructure, including the North Carolina Translational and Clinical Sciences (NC TraCS) Institute, provides scalable data management and analytics platforms capable of supporting complex R&D workflows.
- **Clinical Trial Infrastructure:** UNC Health utilizes decentralized and hybrid trial models to improve patient access and trial recruitment efficiency, offering a scalable framework that aligns with current biopharmaceutical needs for faster study execution.

- **Computational Biology Capabilities:** UNC maintains advanced high-performance computing resources and core facilities capable of processing large-scale genomic and proteomic datasets, which are essential for the "fast design-build-test-learn" cycles utilized in modern drug development.
- **Talent Development:** Eli Lilly maintains a formal internship and corporate hiring program focused on technical and data-driven roles, providing a direct pipeline for graduates from UNC's data science and biomedical informatics programs.

References

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